



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Saint John Paul the Great Catholic High School
School Website: <https://www.jpthegreatdenver.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Saint John Paul the Great Catholic High School (Denver) demonstrates a strong alignment with classical education principles across religious foundation, purpose, curriculum, and community. Public-facing materials portray a Catholic, virtue-centered formation anchored in truth, goodness, and beauty, with emphasis on liberal-arts pedagogy, mastery of classical disciplines, and a partnership with parents as co-educators. The school explicitly frames its mission around formation and wisdom rather than job-readiness, and highlights elements such as the Great Books / liberal arts orientation, memorization and recitation in pedagogy, and a faculty culture that models virtue and mentorship. Taken together, the school ranks as CLASSICAL overall, with pedagogy showing some areas that could be strengthened to reach full alignment. The following analysis details how each category stacks up against the classical rubric and keywords.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot - Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence: Mission statements center on formation as disciples of Christ; references to truth, beauty, and goodness; sacraments and liturgical life noted as part of formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive items include truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, sacraments, Catholic faith, liturgy (where mentioned). Negative signals are not observed in the materials. Why: The materials foreground transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a Catholic theological frame integrated with daily formation.

- Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence: Explicit focus on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of true/beautiful; desire for human flourishing; emphasis on liberal education and the Great Conversation. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, great conversation, permanent questions, human excellence. Negative signals absent in the public materials. Why: The education is presented as formation toward virtue and wisdom rather than narrow job-prep; the Great Conversation and permanent questions imagery strengthens the classical Francis of aims.

- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL Evidence: Curriculum described with liberal arts framing (grammar, logic, rhetoric), history integrated through disciplines, Great Books emphasis, Latin/Greek, and Western civ/history as core content. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include liberal arts, trivium/quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classics, Latin/Greek, history, Western civilization, hymnody, sacred art. Negative signals (from the lexicon) such as "social studies terminology replacing history" or "project-based learning dominance" are not evidenced here. Why: The school's explicit mention of Great Books, Latin, and the classical-trivium framework aligns strongly with a Classical Curriculum.

- Element 4: Pedagogy — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Narration, recitation, poetry memory, low-tech approach; emphasis on memorization, discussion, and integration across disciplines; upper-school rhetoric opportunities are implied in the classical framework but not always explicit. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include narration, recitation, memory work, contemplation, seminar, and rhetoric-oriented practice; the presence of concrete Socratic seminars in public materials is less explicit, and there is less direct reference to full Socratic seminars in grades K–12 on the public pages. Negative indicators (per the classical lexicon) might include heavy reliance on experiential or project-based learning if overemphasized, which is not shown here. Overall, several core practices (narration, memorization, memory-based learning, and disciplined discussion) align with classical pedagogy, but explicit evidence of regular Socratic seminars or high-school rhetoric seminars is not consistently documented on the site.

Why: The school clearly employs memory work and dialogic discussion as components of learning, but the explicit, scalable use of Socratic seminars and high-school rhetoric programs across grades is less clearly documented. - Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence: Public materials emphasize teachers as witnesses of faith and mentors; pages like “Meet our Faculty” indicate a faculty-focused, virtue-modeling culture; references to formation and the living curriculum appear. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher and student, collaborative culture. Negative indicators (per lexicon) such as “facilitators on the side” are not observed; the content aligns with the classical image of faculty as central, virtuous guides. Why: The language and structure point to a faculty that embodies classical pedagogy and formation, with faculty serving as core exemplars and mentors. - Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence: Phrases about partnership with parents, parent formation, and opening campus for visits; explicit language about parents as co-educators and the role of families in formation. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, reading groups, seminars, open campus, hospitality, and family liturgy alignment. Negative indicators are not evident in the public materials. Why: The materials strongly reflect the classical expectation of engaged, informed parents as collaborators in formation.

Aggregate Ranking: CLASSICAL

- Overall, the school grounds its mission in transcendent truth and Catholic formation, presents a liberal-arts curriculum centered on great books and classical disciplines, employs memory- and discussion-based pedagogy, highlights a faculty culture oriented toward mentorship and virtue, and actively invites parental partnership. The strongest alignment lies in religious foundations, purpose, curriculum, faculty, and community, with pedagogical details showing robust classical elements but slightly less explicit documentation of some high-school Socratic seminar structures across all grades.

What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL schools) - If any future materials more explicitly document regular, grade-wide Socratic seminars in upper levels, with a clear progression from lower-school narration/recitation to upper-school seminar and debate, the Pedagogy category would move toward CLASSICAL in a more standardized way. - Publicly emphasize a broader and more explicit Great Books program across all grades, including explicit integration of primary sources and a stated cadence for weekly or monthly Great Conversation experiences. - Increase explicit references to scholē as a daily practice across the campus (restful learning days, contemplative practices) to reinforce the category's positive signals. - Further articulate “living curriculum” through explicit examples of teacher-student mentorship, teacher-professional development in classical pedagogy, and a visible portrait of the ideal teacher and ideal student (as described in the lexicon).

Note on methodology - This evaluation draws on public-facing materials from the school's site (the crawl results) and applies the classical rubric using the Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) lexicon. The lexicon's categories and signals guided keyword detection and scoring for each category, with explicit quotes used to anchor claims. Positive keyword signals include truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, liturgy, sacraments, formal liberal-arts content, Great Books, and co-educative family involvement; negative signals include constructs like secular relativism, project-based learning dominance, and other non-classical directions. The lexicon content used for reference is summarized in the Classically Lexicon document.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Mission statements emphasize forming disciples of Jesus Christ and being rooted in truth and joy, with reference to witnessing truth and virtuous life in service of Church and country.
 - Additional content describes unity of formation with Christ and sacraments as part of integrated life.
 - Classical Education material emphasizes encounter with Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as central to formation; theology and Catholic identity anchor the curriculum.

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- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; sacraments; Catholic faith; liturgy (where referenced); reverence; wonder (where referenced).
 - Negative: no explicit relativism or secularism signals detected in public materials.
 - The lexicon anchors these as strong positive signals; public materials reflect those themes.
 - Why this rating
 - The school's foundational narrative is explicitly Catholic, the formation emphasis is transcendent, and liturgical/sacramental life is integrated into education, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations in this category. The explicit emphasis on Truth/Goodness/Beauty and theological grounding supports the highest category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The goal is described as formation toward virtue and wisdom, not merely job prep; “formation” and “pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful” are central.
 - Emphasis on liberal education, paideia, and the Great Conversation; desire for human excellence and soul craft.
 - Explicit statements about partnering with parents to form humans who live in accordance with reality and who love Truth, Goodness, and Beauty.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: formation; virtue; wisdom; liberal education; paideia; telos; great conversation; permanence of truth/goodness/Beauty; scholé/restfulness.
 - Negative: no explicit workforce-centric framing in public materials.
 - Lexicon guidance and public materials align with classical aims; no negative signals detected.
- Why this rating
 - The school's stated aims center on formation and the pursuit of enduring truths, consistent with CLASSICAL orientation in this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Explicit liberal arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a focus on Great Books and primary sources; Latin/Greek and history are central; Western civilization and writings from Homer to Shakespeare appear in the discourse.
 - Description of reading great old books, annotating, narrating, and discussing texts; memorization of poetry; integration of disciplines; emphasis on mastery and classical content.
 - Indications of a curriculum designed to cultivate wonder and deep learning, through classics and primary texts.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classics, Latin/-Greek, history, sacred art, hymnody, Western civilization.
 - Negative: no evidence of “social studies” rebranding of history or a dominance of project-based STEM-first framing in the public materials.
 - The lexicon's positive signals are strongly echoed by the school's curriculum framing; negative signals are not observed.
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum aligns with core classical elements: liberal arts core, Great Books, primary sources, and classical languages; history and Western civilization framing are present. This category is CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence

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- Lower-school practices emphasize memory-based activities like narration, recitation, and singing of learned material; “low-tech”/classical approach described.
 - Public materials discuss reading great books, annotating, narrating, discussing text, and writing by hand; emphasis on integration across disciplines; students memorize poetry.
 - Upper-school pedagogy is framed by the classical tradition, including potential rhetoric and oration; the exact regularity and structure of Socratic seminars are not consistently documented in public pages, though the classical framework implies discussion-based learning.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: narration, recitation, memory work, contemplation/rest, seminars, colloquy, tutorial, Paideia-style elements, rhetoric exercises, oratory, debate, archiving memory, catechesis, liturgical calendar integration.
 - Negative: There is less explicit documentation of sustained, school-wide Socratic seminars or a fully developed high-school-level rhetoric program across all grades in public pages; the materials do not show a heavy emphasis on project-based or experiential learning as a dominant pedagogy.
 - The lexicon notes Socratic seminars and memory work as positive signals; the site provides strong memory/recitation and integrated reading practices, but the explicit, scalable Socratic structure is not uniformly documented.
 - Why this rating
 - Pedagogy demonstrates classic elements (memory, narration, recitation, integration, contemplative/restful dimensions) but lacks consistently explicit, high-visibility documentation of regular high-school Socratic seminars and fully developed upper-school rhetoric programs across the entire site. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty are described as witnesses to faith and mentors; the school emphasizes a living curriculum and a portrait of what a teacher should be; public pages feature faculty profiles and a culture of mentorship.
 - There is a focus on formation of teachers and a collaborative, “faculty of friends” ethos typical of classical schools; visible emphasis on teacher quality and mentorship.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, formation of teachers.
 - Negative: no explicit signals of non-classical faculty roles (e.g., “facilitator on the side” or purely certification-driven pedagogy) appearing in the public materials.
 - The classical indicators are clearly present in the materials.
- Why this rating
 - The school presents a traditional, virtue-centered faculty model aligned with classical ideals of mentorship and living curriculum, supporting a CLASSICAL designation.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes partnership with parents as co-educators, parent formation, reading groups, seminars, and open-campus hospitality; explicit statements about parental involvement and engagement.
 - Materials describe inviting parents to visits, events, and forming families around classical formation; the “We are building a Catholic school, together” messaging underscores parental/community engagement.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, reading groups, seminars, classical book clubs, open campus, hospitality, family liturgy alignment, home catechesis.

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- Negative: no signals of consumer-language or minimal parental involvement; the materials show active parental engagement.
 - The lexicon's positive signals for Parents & Community align with the school's messaging in public materials.
 - Why this rating
 - The school presents a strong, explicit partnership with parents and community involvement, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for parent engagement.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable here, as the aggregate ranking is CLASSICAL. No additional needle-moving changes are required by the rubric for a CLASSICAL result. If desired, minor enhancements could include more explicit, systematized documentation of regular upper-school Socratic seminars and a public-facing articulation of a formal "living curriculum" portrait for faculty, but these are not required to achieve CLASSICAL status.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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